

CEEIC: The force behind CEF

China Electronics Exhibition & Information Communication Co., Ltd (CEEIC) has been organising CEF since 1964. It is a subsidiary of China Electronic Appliance Corporation (CEAC).

Apart from organising exhibitions, CEEIC also organises academy seminars, technology seminars and new product promotion conferences, actively promoting the scientific institution of electronics and communication fields, and the communication between production and circulation departments.

More than half of the exhibitors who we talked to, are interested in tapping the Indian market. And, many of these firms are amongst the top three players in their domestic market (China) in respective segments, which means that not only can they compete on high volumes and pricing but have also attained a certain level of quality already. In fact, most of them have already got their products certified for international quality standards.

Thus, at CEF you get to meet some of the major Chinese players who are looking to expand into India but are not sure how to do that. Many of them are looking for distributors and sales-agents, while some are even reviewing the option of opening an office in India. For those looking at suppliers, almost all are eager. While some are particular about maintaining their brand, most are open to the idea of becoming an OEM supplier.

It's not that easy either

However, if you think that by simply attending CEF you will be able to sign up a new principal or get an agency of a leading Chinese brand, think again. The biggest challenge (and opportunity) lies in the fact that most of the exhibitors at CEF are not marketing savvy, unlike their Hong Kong or Taiwanese counterparts. One third were yet to start exports—they had grown so far based entirely on

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the internal demand. Thus, while they are open to the idea of exports, they may not have clear-cut answers. To top that, many will not have English speaking staff at their booth, or they will have limited vocabulary. Overall, only one-third of the exhibitors we met had fluent-English speaking staff at their booths.

An interesting aspect that emerged from our discussions is that there is a lack of follow-up amongst Indian delegates. Many exhibitors expressed their frustration that while the talks at the expo seem very enthusiastic, and signing of a deal seems imminent, they hardly get to hear from their Indian counterparts despite repeated reminders once the show gets over.

At CEF, you will also encounter a few booths which are looking at only domestic sales. You can save a lot of your precious time by avoiding these.

Proactiveness could be the key

Clearly, though many cases seem like low-hanging fruits, it will need smart tactics and perseverance by savvy entrepreneurs to taste success. Here are a few tips that we can share with you, based on our own experience, and that of other international buyers we met at the show:

1. Do as much research before-hand as possible. You can get a list of exhibitors attending CEF from their website 'http://www.icef.com.cn/fall_eng/'. From this list, try and identify those which belong to the segment that you are targeting, and then read about them from their websites.

2. Try and set up formal appointments before-hand so that their global

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sales team is there, and their top-shots are also in loop.

3. Ensure that you have a seasoned interpreter with you—so that language is not a barrier. Many a times, their English-speaking team-mate might have a limited vocabulary. Plus, there is a huge difference between the way we pronounce things, and they do. So, having an interpreter can speed up the discussion, and help you reach decisions faster.

4. Go for the leaders first. They have the financial muscle and all the correct connections to make sure that all stops are removed once their organisation decides to go ahead and partner with you. Typically, you will get to interact with the top-three (or even top-five) Chinese firms for different segments of the Chinese electronics industry.

5. Do not talk about the price first. If the quantities go up, many of them can drop prices to unimaginable levels. But, if they feel that the entire deal is based on one parameter, i.e., price, they may not show a very enthusiastic response. Instead, try to focus more on how they pitch their organisation's USP, and the values that back their brand and their organisation. If you are able to show a match in organisational values, and a long-term commitment, the price will not be an issue, as the size of the deal expands.

6. Try to keep extra days in hand after the event, so that if things take a positive turn the deals can be closed then and there. Or else, make sure that things are not forgotten about once you return, and that communication channel is kept open. ●

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